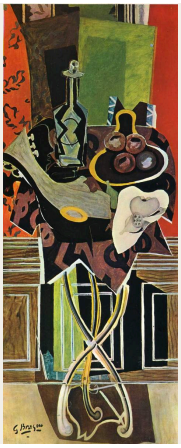
PARIS, FRANCE

Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou: Masterpieces

Twenty works that reorganise the relation between a recognisable subject and a painted surface.



A window usually offers a view through something. A painting can do that too, but the works in this selection repeatedly interrupt the passage. Braque's objects break into planes; Kandinsky's colours need no objects at all; a painted wooden head by Taeuber-Arp makes likeness coexist with conspicuous construction.

These are different choices, not successive rungs on a ladder towards abstraction. Valadon's reclining woman and Balthus's courtyard retain recognisable rooms while asking how a figure or a frame controls our access to them. Across the selection, the useful question is where the eye is allowed to travel and where it meets the surface. The guide concerns collection works, not their current exhibition locations.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/centre-pompidou-collection

The selection · 20

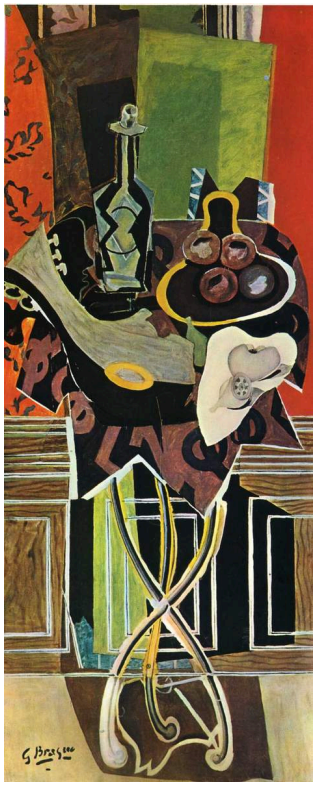
1. A Red Pedestal
   Georges Braque · 1939
2. Bust of a Young Woman from Avignon
   Pablo Picasso · 1907
3. Fruit Dish
   Georges Braque · 1913
4. Lolotte
   Amedeo Modigliani · 1916
5. Memory of the Halls of Mirrors in Brussels
   Otto Dix · 1920
6. Yellow-Red-Blue
   Wassily Kandinsky · 1925
7. Paranoiac Woman-Horse
   Salvador Dalí · 1930
8. Painting, 146 × 114 cm, 1950
   Pierre Soulages · 1950
9. Portrait of Erik Satie
   Suzanne Valadon · c. 1892
10. Still Life with an Antique Bust
    Pablo Picasso · 1925
11. The Moon-Woman Cuts the Circle
    Jackson Pollock · 1943
12. The Palace of Window Rocks
    Yves Tanguy · 1942
13. The Poultry Yard
    Henri Rousseau · 1896 - 1898
14. The Serenade
    Pablo Picasso · 1942
15. Window, Cour de Rohan
    Balthus · 1951
16. Figure
    Joan Miró · 1934
17. The Blue Room
    Suzanne Valadon · 1923
18. Dada Head
    Sophie Taeuber-Arp · 1920
19. Sky Blue
    Wassily Kandinsky · 1940
20. The King's Sadness
    Henri Matisse · 1952

01 / 20

A Red Pedestal

Georges Braque

1939 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Georges Braque. A Red Pedestal. WikiArt source label: Georges Braque Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georges-braque/a-red-pedestal-1939 · Georges Braque Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The stand gives Braque's overlapping planes something to gather around. Vessels remain recognisable, but their positions do not resolve into an entirely consistent view. The red vertical area repeatedly returns attention to the tall structure. It functions as an anchor without cancelling the smaller uncertainties through which each object meets its neighbours.

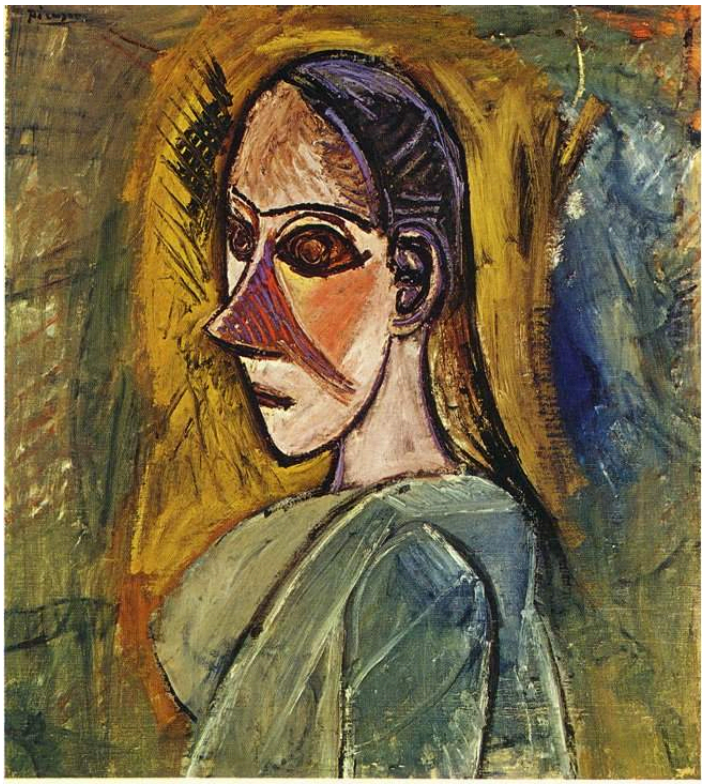
Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Bust of a Young Woman from Avignon

Pablo Picasso

1907 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Pablo Picasso. Bust of young woman from Avignon. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/bust-of-young-woman-from-avignon-1907 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Dark contours divide the face into separate areas instead of smoothing its surfaces into continuous flesh. The broad shoulder and turned head still establish a bust, but the construction makes the familiar format difficult to take for granted. Picasso preserves enough of the figure to register how strongly its parts have been made to resist a unified viewpoint.

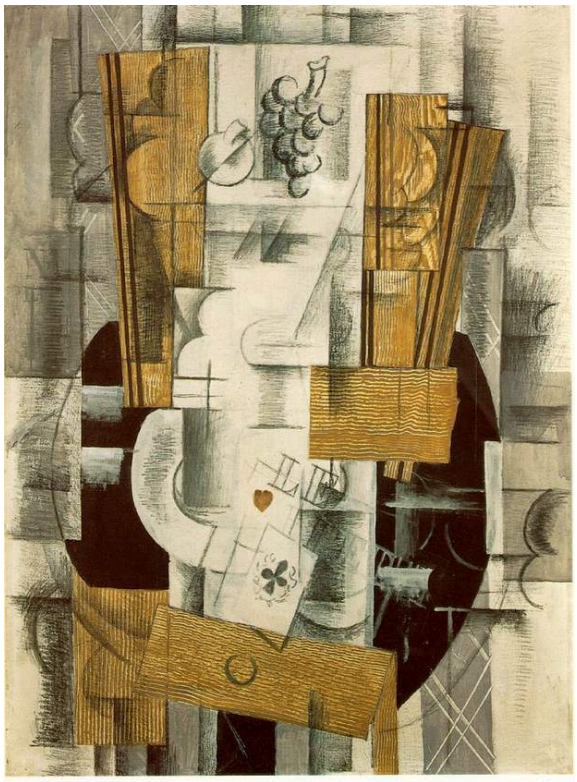
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Fruit Dish

Georges Braque

1913 · Charcoal, gouache and oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Georges Braque. Fruit Dish. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georges-braque/fruit-dish-1913 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

A dish, fruit and table must be assembled from incomplete clues. Lines continue across areas whose tones or textures pull them back towards the flat surface. Braque permits both readings to remain active: the marks indicate objects, yet their arrangement is never merely a transparent view of those objects. The effort of recognition becomes part of looking.

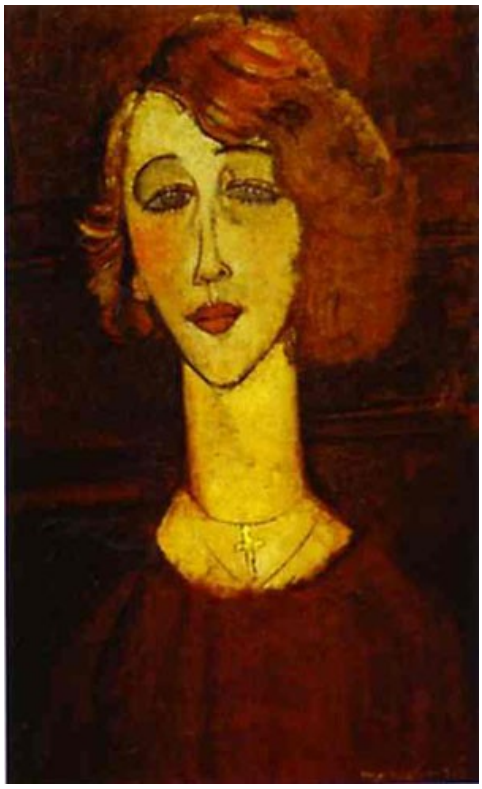
Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Lolotte

Amedeo Modigliani

1916 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Amedeo Modigliani. Lolotte. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/amedeo-modigliani/lolotte-1916 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The long neck extends the portrait's vertical movement between dark clothing and red hair. Modigliani repeats curves without making the face perfectly symmetrical or interchangeable. Small differences in the eyes and mouth interrupt the larger regularity. The portrait holds a particular sitter within an openly stylised construction rather than asking elongation to pass unnoticed as natural proportion.

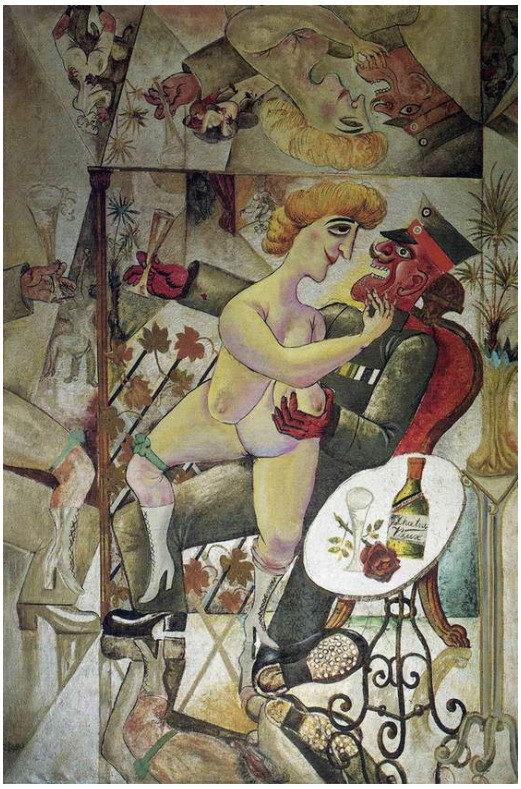
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Memory of the Halls of Mirrors in Brussels

Otto Dix

1920 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d'art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Otto Dix. Memory of the Halls of Mirrors in Brussels. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/otto-dix/memory-of-the-halls-of-mirrors-in-brussels · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Mirrors should multiply a room, but here multiplication makes the room harder to reconstruct. Figures, furnishings and reflected fragments meet at abrupt angles. Dix leaves few reliable passages through the crowded interior. The title names a memory, not an architectural survey; the broken arrangement allows a scene to remain insistent without becoming spatially coherent.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Yellow-Red-Blue

Wassily Kandinsky

1925 · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Wassily Kandinsky. Yellow-Red-Blue. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The left and right halves behave differently. Angular yellow forms spread on one side, while darker circular masses and curling lines gather on the other; red areas help negotiate their meeting. Kandinsky does not need a depicted event to establish movement. Unequal weights and contrasting kinds of edge make the eye continually reconsider the balance.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Paranoiac Woman-Horse

Salvador Dalí

1930 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Salvador Dalí. Paranoiac Woman-Horse (Invisible Sleeping Woman, Lion, Horse). WikiArt source label: Salvador Dali Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/salvador-dali/paranoiac-woman-horse-invisible-sleeping-woman-lion-horse · Salvador Dali Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The shadows seem more certain than the things casting them. Dalí gives the low landscape and its ambiguous forms a precise illumination, while their contours suggest more than one possible body. Realistic description becomes a means of sustaining uncertainty. The task is not necessarily to solve the image once, but to notice how one identification displaces another.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Painting, 146 × 114 cm, 1950

Pierre Soulages

1950 · Oil · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Pierre Soulages. Peinture 146 x 114 cm, 1950. WikiArt source label: Pierre Soulages Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pierre-soulages/peinture-146-x-114-cm-1950-1950 · Pierre Soulages Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Black occupies much of the surface, but it is not uniform. The broad strokes cross, overlap and leave small pale openings whose shapes alter the surrounding weight. Their edges reveal differences of direction and pressure. Soulages gives the title the restraint of a catalogue description while leaving the relationships among the marks to supply the painting's incident.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Portrait of Erik Satie

Suzanne Valadon

c. 1892 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Suzanne Valadon. Portrait of Erik Satie. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/suzanne-valadon/portrait-of-erik-satie · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The close framing gives little room to a setting beyond Satie's hat and coat. Warmer colours distinguish the face and beard within that dark surround. Valadon concentrates on the angle of the head and the sitter's directed gaze. The portrait can establish a bearing without furnishing the room with attributes intended to explain a composer's whole career.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Still Life with an Antique Bust

Pablo Picasso

1925 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Pablo Picasso. Still life with antique bust. WikiArt source label: Pablo Picasso Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/still-life-with-antique-bust-1925 · Pablo Picasso Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

A bust brings an expectation of solid, modelled volume into a room divided by sharp planes. Around it, orange, white and black areas make depth difficult to follow consistently. Picasso subjects the classical object to the same unstable surroundings as the vessels. Its familiar solidity supplies a point of comparison, not a guarantee that the room will become coherent.

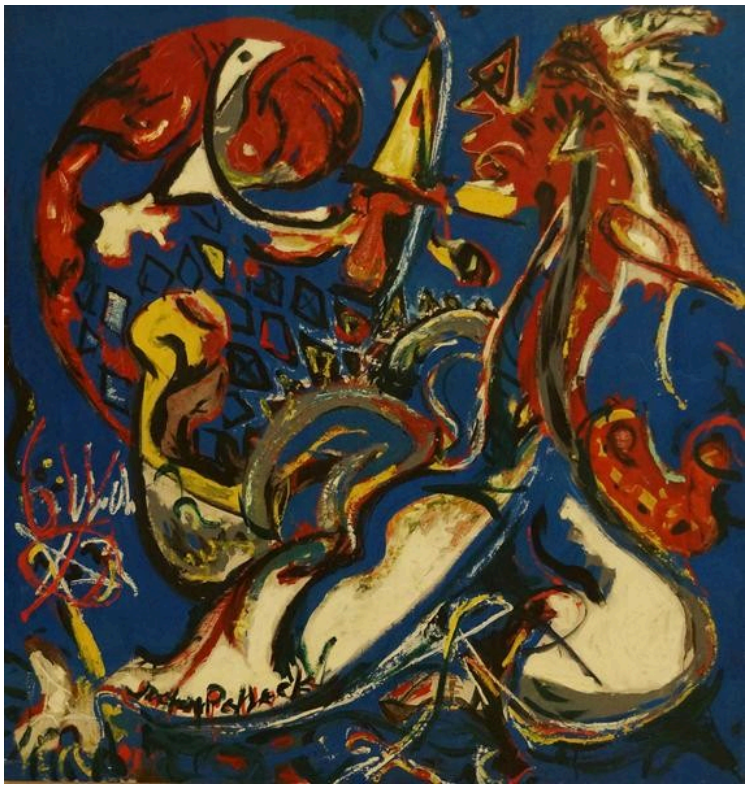
Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

The Moon-Woman Cuts the Circle

Jackson Pollock

1943 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



The Moon-Woman Cuts the Circle. WikiArt; Jackson Pollock. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Jackson Pollock

Suggestions of figures persist inside the dense lines and coloured marks. They are not cleanly separated from the activity around them, so the eye moves between possible bodies and the surface connecting them. Pollock allows recognition without giving it complete control. Curves and pointed forms can operate as parts of a figure and as interruptions in a larger pattern.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

The Palace of Window Rocks

Yves Tanguy

1942 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Yves Tanguy. The Palace of Window Rocks. WikiArt source label: Yves Tanguy Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/yves-tanguy/palace-on-windows-rocks · Yves Tanguy Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The objects have clear shadows but no clear use. Tanguy's low plain provides the rules of a plausible landscape, making the scattered forms appear to stand securely in space. Their unfamiliarity is sharpened by that certainty. A less convincing ground would make them easier to dismiss as free-floating shapes; here they seem to belong somewhere, even when their purpose remains unavailable.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

The Poultry Yard

Henri Rousseau

1896 - 1898 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d'art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Henri Rousseau. The Poultry Yard. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henri-rousseau/the-poultry-yard-1898 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Paths, fences and buildings divide the yard into readable compartments. Rousseau gives the setting a pronounced order before the small birds introduce irregular movement within it. The contrast does not require an exotic subject. An ordinary enclosure becomes worth examining because its boundaries are so emphatic and the creatures inside do not follow their straight lines.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

The Serenade

Pablo Picasso

1942 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



The serenade. WikiArt; Pablo Picasso. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Pablo Picasso

A reclining yellow figure and an upright musician occupy different directions within the angular room. Their relation remains intelligible despite the fractured setting: one performs, the other receives the performance. Picasso separates their positions through colour and bodily arrangement. The image can therefore sustain a recognisable social situation without providing a naturalistic account of either body.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Window, Cour de Rohan

Balthus

1951 · Oil on canvas · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Balthus. Window, Cour de Rohan. WikiArt source label: Balthus Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/balthus/window-cour-de-rohan-1951 · Balthus Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The opposite building is not offered directly. It is reached through the open window, past the sill and nearby objects, within a succession of enclosing edges. Balthus makes these intervals more consequential than any activity in the courtyard. The subject is partly the view and partly the measured distance that prevents the view from merging with the room.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Figure

Joan Miró

1934 · Pastel on paper · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Character. WikiArt; Joan Miró. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Joan Miro

A head, curved arms and feet provide enough signs for a body, despite proportions that would not support a person in ordinary space. Miró sets the sharply bounded figure against softer surrounding colour. Gesture remains legible because of the relation among a few parts. Adding anatomical information might clarify the body while weakening the economy of that relation.

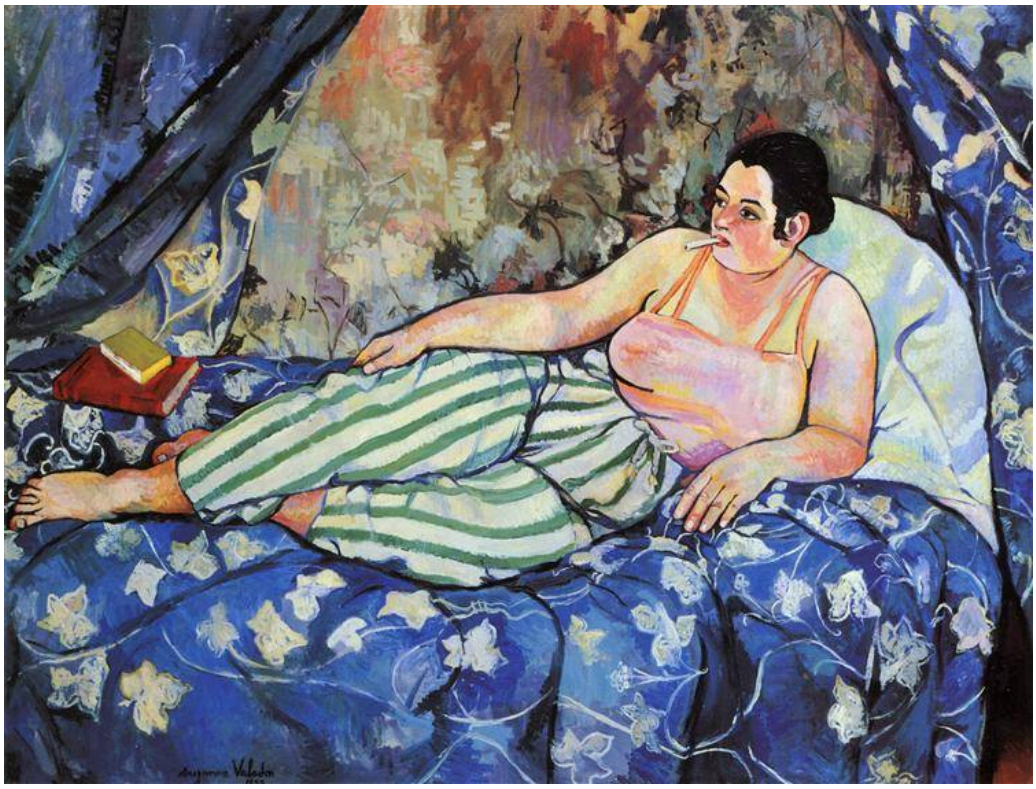
Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

The Blue Room

Suzanne Valadon

1923 · Musée national d'art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Suzanne Valadon. The Blue Room. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Striped trousers and a blue patterned bed keep clothing and furnishings visibly active around the reclining woman. Books add an ordinary use to the room rather than turning it into an empty setting for a pose. Valadon gives the figure bodily weight without requiring a display of idealised anatomy. The surrounding patterns do not diminish her occupation of the space.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Dada Head

Sophie Taeuber-Arp

1920 · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Sophie Taeuber-Arp. Dada Head. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The rounded volume promises a head, while its painted geometry declines to complete a naturalistic face. Taeuber-Arp makes these two kinds of information coexist on an object mounted on a narrow stand. The colour does not simply describe the form beneath it. It divides that form according to another order, keeping construction visible alongside resemblance.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Sky Blue

Wassily Kandinsky

1940 · Musée national d’art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Wassily Kandinsky. Sky Blue. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The gaps are as conspicuous as the floating forms. Each small shape has its own curves, stripes or appendages, yet the continuous blue holds them within one field. Kandinsky avoids making them coalesce into a single mass. Their separateness gives the eye room to move from one internal pattern to another without losing the surrounding space.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

The King's Sadness

Henri Matisse

1952 · Musée national d'art moderne — Centre Pompidou



Henri Matisse. The King's Sadness. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The yellow instrument and scattered leaf-like shapes bring small movements to the broad coloured areas. Matisse's cut forms suggest bodies and performance without modelling their depth. Clean edges make overlapping activity readable even when the scene is crowded. The title supplies an emotional proposition; the shapes do not have to imitate a sorrowful facial expression to give that proposition a setting.

Object source · Open artwork

Compare the boundaries

Put Braque's uncertain tabletop beside Balthus's carefully framed view, then return to Kandinsky's open blue field. These are three different accounts of pictorial space. Collection ownership does not establish present display: use the Centre Pompidou's current programme and object records to locate works before travelling.

Further reading

Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by Michael Sadleir · Read free · English

Concerning the Spiritual in Art gives Kandinsky's own account of his ambitions for colour and abstract form. It is a historical argument by one artist, useful beside these works but not a rulebook for every artist in the selection.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Musée national d'art moderne — Centre Pompidou: Masterpieces